🚩 The Russian Revolution: Reading

World History · Unit 5 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Bolshevik slides and questions, Marx & Lenin compare and Rule of Stalin reading

Name: _____

Revolutions in Russia

In the early 1900s, Russia was ruled by Czar Nicholas II, an autocrat with total power. Most Russians were poor peasants, and factory workers labored long hours for low pay. Reformers like Pyotr Stolypin tried land reforms, but he was assassinated in 1911. World War I brought millions of deaths and food shortages. In March 1917, riots forced Nicholas to give up the throne, ending 300 years of Romanov rule.

Karl Marx's Communist Manifesto (1848) predicted that workers would overthrow the owners of factories and create a society where property is shared. Vladimir Lenin adapted these ideas. Marx believed workers would rise up on their own; Lenin believed a small, disciplined party of revolutionaries had to lead them and use force.

A provisional government led by Alexander Kerensky replaced the czar, but it lost support by continuing the war. Lenin's Bolsheviks promised 'Peace, Land and Bread' and seized power in November 1917. Leon Trotsky negotiated the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, which took Russia out of the war but gave up a great deal of land to Germany. From 1918 to 1920, the Bolsheviks' Red Army fought a civil war against the White Army, a loose group of opponents. The Reds won, and in 1922 Russia became the Soviet Union.

After Lenin died in 1924, Joseph Stalin ('Man of Steel') took control. He created a totalitarian state that controlled the economy, the media, schools and religion. His Five-Year Plans built industry rapidly, and he forced peasants onto collective farms. Anyone seen as an enemy could be sent to labor camps or executed. Millions of people died from famine and terror under his rule.

Check your reading

1. Give two reasons Russians turned against Czar Nicholas II.

2. How did Lenin's ideas differ from Marx's?

3. What is a totalitarian state? Give one example from Stalin's rule.